the general election, where it secured 99 seats, has also left the allies unimpressed. While the party credited the Rahul-led Bharat Jodo Yatras for the increased tally, a deeper analysis of the results showed that the Congress, in fact, underperformed in several of the key states it passed through during the yatra, particularly in those where it was in a direct contest with the BJP.

In Karnataka, for instanc, where expectations ran high after the stupendous victory in the 2023 assembly poll, the party managed just nine seats compared to the BJP's 17 in the Lok Sabha iteration. The top three regional parties in the INDIA bloc also outdid the Congress in terms of the strike rate in their respective states. In Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal and Tamil Nadu—three big states accounting for 161 seats—the Samajwadi Party (SP), TMC and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhakam (DMK) collectively won 88 seats, or 55 per cent, of the total. The Congress tally of seats came out of the 326 it contested across the country—a strike rate of 30 per cent.

Why the Allies are Angry

For the allies, there are also larger issues: the Congress's alleged inability to adapt to the dynamics of coalition politics, its dismissive attitude towards partners, and obsession with certain narratives that many believe are politically counterproductive. At the centre of the discontent is Rahul, whose leadership style, priorities and public behaviour have become flashpoints. Allies have openly expressed their frustration with what they see as Rahul's narrow and repetitive focus on issues like the Adani Group and Veer Savarkar, topics, they argue, have limited resonance with voters and, worse, alienate key constituencies. Mamata had even before the Lok Sabha polls subtly hinted her disapproval by proposing Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge as the INDIA bloc's prime ministerial face—a proposal Kejriwal had supported.

A major source of frustration for the allies is Rahul's preoccupation with crony capitalism, specifically his attacks on the Adani Group. While the allegations are serious and have rattled the Narendra Modi-led government, allies like Mamata, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, and even AAP leaders believe that overemphasis on the issue is a strategic mistake. The TMC, for example, openly boycotted the Congress-led protests on the Adani issue in Parliament, with senior party leaders like Abhishek Banerjee stating that voters are far more concerned about inflation, unemployment and welfare delivery than about corporate controversies. SP leaders have also quietly expressed annoyance, saying the constant attacks on Adani do little to address the bread-and-butter concerns of the UP electorate.

Another contentious issue has been the Congress's campaigns like 'EVM Jagao Yatra', about the alleged tampering of voting machines. TMC's Abhishek openly criticised it, urging the party to focus on booth-level management rather than conspiracy theories while J&K CM Omar Abdullah of the National Conference (NC) sarcastically remarked that the Congress cannot celebrate victories achieved through EVM voting and then turn around and blame the machines when the verdict goes against it.

FRICTION POINTS



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CROSSED WIRES
Rahul Gandhi with Arvind Kejriwal in a file picture

- **Crushing losses in Haryana, Maharashtra give allies reason to challenge the Congress leadership of INDIA bloc**
- **Mamata Banerjee's bid to take the lead causes unease; Congress resists move**
- **Allies like TMC and SP criticise Congress's focus on Adani, say it distracts from core voter concerns. Calls campaigns like 'EVM Jagao Yatra' unproductive**
- **Resentment against Congress dominance and its reluctance to collaborate. INDIA bloc leaders have not met formally since June '24**
- **Delhi Congress's no-holds-barred attack on AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal exposes fragile, transactional nature of bloc's unity**

In the Congress, planning is easy, execution difficult. Kharge's warnings haven't reduced the infighting problem